

ANI

A novice at politics, she stepped into the vacuum as if to the manner born, building a narrative of defiance around the idea that Hemant had been wronged. Jharkhand's tribals were listening—the results were proof of that. Others tuned in too, as she shared the national stage with the similarly jailed Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal's wife Sunita, on INDIA bloc platforms. The poise and articulacy were striking. Kalpana emerged as an improbable saviour in round one. Daughter of an army officer, she had long eschewed politics, choosing instead the quiet role of a supportive spouse. But her husband's incarceration forced her into the political arena. By June, she had contested and won the Gandey byelection, underscoring her transformation from a reluctant participant to a formidable political force.

When Hemant walked out of jail on June 28, sporting a beard that evoked the visage of his father, he returned to a state in turmoil but found solace in his comrade-in-arms, who had steadied the ship during his absence and created her own axis to the people. Challenges abounded. A month after Hemant reclaimed the CM's post on July 4, Champai defected to the BJP. But the transformation of Hemant-Kalpana, forged in the crucible of crisis, was only unfolding.

The fruits of the duo's labour ripened on November 23, when the JMM-led INDIA bloc swept the polls, clinching 56 seats to the NDA's 24

What ensued was a masterclass in how to turn crisis into opportunity, with bold initiatives to counteract anti-incumbency and reinvigorate the JMM's appeal. The Maiya Samman Yojana, launched in August, offered financial assistance to over five million women. It was strategically brilliant populism, cutting across the tribal/non-tribal divide that had hitherto hemmed in the JMM.

Then election season closed in, demanding every ounce of the couple's combined fortitude. Kalpana, now a linchpin of the JMM's campaign machinery, anchored herself in Giridih in the north and crisscrossed the state tirelessly. Over a hundred rallies later, the power of her charm offensive was clear: she had a knack for connecting with women voters. Hemant, addressing rallies across Ranchi and beyond, complemented her efforts, their synergy blunting even the BJP's formidable central leadership. On November 23, it was declared a sweep: the JMM-led INDIA bloc had 56 seats to the NDA's 24. For the first time ever, a Jharkhand CM returned to power. A woman walked with him. ■